

Everything SATS — Reading Mock 1

Reading booklet

This is an original practice paper written for Everything SATS. It follows the layout and question types of the real Key Stage 2 English reading test, but it is **not** a real past paper.

There are three texts in this booklet:

1. Puffins: Clowns of the Sea
2. The Hedgehog Highway
3. The Girl on the Promenade

Print this booklet and the question booklet. Read one text, answer its questions, then move on to the next text.

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Puffins: Clowns of the Sea

This text gives information about the Atlantic puffin, a seabird that nests around the coasts of the UK.

Picture a small black-and-white seabird standing on a clifftop, its bright orange feet planted in the grass and its enormous, stripy beak glowing in the sunshine. This is the Atlantic puffin, one of the best-loved birds in Britain, and it is easy to see why people call it the 'clown of the sea'.

Where do puffins live?

Atlantic puffins live in the North Atlantic Ocean. For most of the year, they are out on the open sea, but every spring they come ashore to raise their young. They gather in large groups called colonies, usually on rocky islands and steep cliffs where there are few animals to disturb them.

In the UK, puffins nest in places such as the Farne Islands off the coast of Northumberland, Skomer Island in Wales, and many of the islands around Scotland, including Orkney and Shetland. Further north, huge colonies can be found in Norway, the Faroe Islands and Iceland, which is home to more puffins than any other country.

Why is the beak so colourful?

A puffin's most famous feature is its beak. In the breeding season, it is striped with orange, yellow and blue-grey, and it seems far too large for such a small bird. Puffins are only about the size of a pigeon, so the beak really does stand out.

Scientists believe the bright colours help puffins to attract a mate and to show that they are healthy and strong. Once the breeding season is over, the colourful outer parts of the beak are shed, leaving it smaller and duller. The puffin's face also turns a darker grey in winter, so a puffin at sea in January looks rather different from the one on a postcard.

Home sweet burrow

Unlike many seabirds, which lay their eggs on bare cliff ledges, puffins nest underground. Using their beaks to loosen the soil and their feet to kick it away, they dig burrows into soft, grassy clifftops. Sometimes they save themselves the effort and move into an old rabbit burrow instead.

Puffins often stay with the same partner for many years, and a pair will usually return to the same burrow each spring. After the burrow has been tidied and lined with grass and feathers, the female lays a single egg. Both parents take turns to keep the egg warm.

Meet the puffling

A baby puffin is called a puffling. It hatches as a fluffy ball of dark grey down and spends the first weeks of its life hidden safely in the burrow. Meanwhile, its parents fly back and forth all day long, bringing it fish to eat.

When the puffling is ready, it leaves the burrow for the first time, usually at night. Darkness helps to hide it from hungry gulls. Alone, it flutters and scrambles down to the water and swims out to sea. From that moment, it must look after itself.

What do puffins eat?

Puffins eat small fish, especially sand eels, which are long, thin, silvery fish that live in shallow seas. They also catch other small fish, such as sprats and young herring.

To catch their food, puffins dive beneath the waves and use their wings to 'fly' underwater, steering with their webbed feet.

Most impressive of all is the way a puffin carries its catch. It can hold several fish at once, lined up crosswise in its beak so that the heads and tails dangle from each side. Its rough tongue presses each fish against spiky points on the roof of its mouth, which means it can keep hold of the fish it has already caught while it opens its beak to snap up another.

Where do puffins go in winter?

By the end of summer, the colonies are empty. Puffins leave the land behind and spend the autumn and winter far out at sea, riding the waves and diving for food. They do not return to land at all until the following spring.

Are puffins in danger?

In some places, puffin numbers have fallen. Changes in the sea can make sand eels and other small fish harder to find, and without enough food, parents struggle to raise their pufflings. In some places, people are working hard to protect the islands where

puffins nest, keeping them free of rats and other animals that might attack eggs and chicks.

So if you are ever lucky enough to visit a puffin colony in summer, stay quiet, keep to the paths and watch closely. You might just see one of these little clowns return home with a beak full of silver fish.

The Hedgehog Highway

In this story, two neighbours discover something unexpected in the garden after a stormy night.

The storm arrived on Friday night, just as Edie was brushing her teeth. It came roaring over the rooftops, rattling the windows in their frames and flinging rain against the glass like handfuls of gravel. Edie lay awake for hours.

By Saturday morning, the storm had blown itself out. The sky was a clean, washed blue, and the garden looked as if a giant had stomped through it. Plant pots lay on their sides. The washing line had snapped. Worst of all, one of the wooden fence panels between Edie's garden and Harry's had crashed flat onto the lawn.

Harry's face appeared in the gap almost at once. He was still in his pyjamas, and his hair was sticking up at the back.

'Did you hear it?' he said. 'Mum says it was the worst storm for years. I thought our roof was going to fly off.'

'Our fence nearly did,' said Edie, stepping over the fallen panel. She was about to say something else when she noticed a small, brown shape tucked against the bottom of the flowerbed, half hidden by a heap of wet leaves.

At first she thought it was a pine cone. Then it moved.

'Harry,' she whispered. 'Come here. Slowly.'

The two of them crouched down. It was a hedgehog, curled into a tight, prickly ball. Its spines were dark with rain, and every few seconds a shiver ran through its body.

'It must have been blown out of its nest,' said Edie. 'Poor thing. Let's take it inside and give it a saucer of milk.'

She was already reaching out when Harry grabbed her sleeve.

'Don't!' he said, so sharply that she jumped. Harry never raised his voice. At school, he was the quiet one who read books about animals during wet play, and he usually let Edie decide things. Now his cheeks were pink, but he did not let go.

'Milk's bad for hedgehogs,' he said. 'It gives them upset tummies. And you shouldn't pick one up with bare hands. I read about it. If you see a hedgehog out in the

daytime, it usually means something's wrong. We need gloves, a box and an old towel. Then we phone a hedgehog rescue.'

Edie stared at him. For a moment, she felt a prickle of annoyance, as sharp as any hedgehog spine. She was the one who had found it, after all. Then she looked at the shivering little creature and swallowed her pride.

'Okay,' she said. 'You're the expert. Tell me what to do.'

Harry blinked, as if he could hardly believe what he had heard. Then he nodded and took charge.

Ten minutes later, everything was ready. Edie had found a cardboard box that had once held her new football boots, and Harry had borrowed his mum's gardening gloves, which were far too big for him. He lined the box with an old towel, then lifted the hedgehog into it as gently as if it were made of glass.

Edie's dad phoned a hedgehog rescue centre that Harry found on the internet. The woman who answered told them to keep the hedgehog somewhere quiet and warm until she could collect it. Harry filled a hot-water bottle, wrapped it in a tea towel and tucked it into one corner of the box, 'so she can move away if she gets too hot,' he explained. Edie added a shallow dish of water. Not milk.

The woman, whose name was Mrs Fennimore, arrived just after lunch in a muddy van with a hedgehog painted on the side. She peered into the box and smiled.

'You did everything right,' she said. 'She's a young female, a bit cold and very hungry, but I think she'll be fine. Who knew what to do?'

Edie pointed at Harry at once. 'He did,' she said. 'I was going to give her milk.'

Harry turned so red that even his ears glowed, but he was smiling too.

Before she left, Mrs Fennimore promised to ring them when the hedgehog was strong enough to go back outside. 'Hedgehogs travel a long way at night looking for food,' she added, 'but fences often block their way. If you're mending that one, why not leave a small gap at the bottom? About the size of a CD case is perfect. We call it a hedgehog highway.'

Two weekends later, Edie's dad and Harry's mum put the fence panel back up. Edie and Harry measured the gap themselves, and Harry painted a tiny sign above it that

read: HEDGEHOG HIGHWAY – PLEASE KEEP CLEAR.

The following evening, Mrs Fennimore's van pulled up outside. This time, the hedgehog was plump and lively. They named her Gale, after the storm. Harry gently tipped the box on its side beside the hedge, and the three of them watched as Gale trundled out, sniffed the air and disappeared through the gap in the fence.

'She knows the way already,' Edie said softly.

Harry grinned. 'Of course she does,' he said. 'It's her highway.'

The Girl on the Promenade

This story is set in an English seaside town in the 1880s, when visitors paid to bathe in the sea from bathing machines.

Every morning in summer, before the visitors had finished their breakfast, Ada Pollard led Bramble down the slipway and onto the sand. The old grey horse knew the work better than she did. He would plod to the first bathing machine, wait while Ada fastened the harness, and then lean into the collar until the wheels groaned and turned.

There were six machines in Grandfather's row, each one a wooden hut on wheels. A lady would climb inside on the beach, change into her bathing costume in private, and then be drawn out into the shallows so that she could step down into the sea without a single stranger glimpsing her. Ada thought it a great deal of fuss over a paddle, but the visitors paid good money for it, and money was not a thing to be sniffed at.

Since the railway had come to Saltwick, visitors arrived in their hundreds every summer. They strolled along the promenade in their fine clothes, twirling parasols, and they looked at the sea as though it had been arranged purely for their entertainment. Ada, who had lived beside it all her life, knew better. The sea belonged to nobody. It could be as gentle as a sleeping cat one day and as savage as a wolf the next.

It was on a bright Tuesday in August that she first noticed the girl.

She sat on a bench at the end of the promenade, with a governess on one side of her and a tartan rug across her knees, even though the day was warm. She wore a white dress and a straw hat trimmed with ribbon. Everything about her was clean and new. Ada looked down at her own bare feet, crusted with sand, and at the hem of her skirt, stiff with salt, and felt something hot and sour rise in her chest.

The girl was there the next day, and the day after that. She never walked on the sand. She never paddled. She only watched, hour after hour, with an expression that Ada could not quite read.

'Stuck-up,' Ada muttered to Bramble, tugging at a buckle. 'Thinks she's too grand for the likes of us.' Bramble flicked an ear, which might have meant anything.

On Friday, a gust of wind came snatching along the shore. It lifted the straw hat clean off the girl's head, bowled it down the steps and sent it skipping across the sand towards the water. The governess gave a shriek and flapped her hands, but she did not move from the bench. Before Ada had time to think, she was running.

She caught the hat just as the first wave reached for it. The ribbon was soaked, but otherwise it was unharmed. Feeling suddenly awkward, Ada carried it up the steps to the promenade.

Up close, the girl was paler than Ada had realised, with shadows beneath her eyes like faint bruises.

'Thank you,' she said. 'I would have fetched it myself, but I am not permitted to go on the sand. Doctor Harland says my chest is weak. I was sent here for the sea air, you see, but I am only allowed to breathe it.' She gave a small, rueful smile. 'I am Lucinda.'

Ada did not know what to say. All week, she had imagined this girl sneering at her from the bench. It had never occurred to her that Lucinda might have been gazing at the sea, and at Ada running freely across the sand, with longing.

'What does it feel like?' Lucinda asked suddenly. 'Is the water very cold?'

Ada considered. 'Cold enough to make you gasp,' she said at last. 'Then it fizzles round your ankles, like lemonade. And the sand sucks at your toes when the wave goes out.'

Lucinda closed her eyes, as though she were storing every word away somewhere safe.

The governess, who had been watching this exchange with deep suspicion, rose from the bench. 'Come, Miss Lucinda,' she said. 'You will take a chill.'

The next morning, Ada was waiting by the steps with something wrapped in a clean handkerchief. Inside was a whelk shell she had found years ago and kept on her windowsill ever since. It was the most precious thing she owned.

'If you hold it to your ear,' Ada said, pushing it into Lucinda's hands before she could change her mind, 'you can hear the sea. Grandfather says that's only make-believe, but I don't believe him.'

Lucinda held it to her ear. For a long moment, she said nothing at all. Then her face broke into a smile so wide and so sudden that Ada, to her own astonishment, found that she was smiling too.

Lucinda went home to London at the end of the month. On her last morning, she pressed a folded note into Ada's hand. It said only: I shall listen to it every night until I come back.

Ada kept the note on her windowsill, in the space where the shell used to be. And each time the train whistle blew across the bay, she found herself looking towards the empty bench at the end of the promenade.